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The Sacrifice We Fail to Appreciate, Continually

Tree Tag # 914

Ever since my very first-time visiting Tree #914 for “Tree Assignment Part 1,” I have returned (on numerous occasions) to work and study underneath my tree at the Garden of Contentment. My initial thoughts are always different, as I perceive new things each time that I revisit my tree with “fresh eyes.” However, I’m always brought back to the very same thought, the same thought/concept that I discussed in my first submitted reflection: how Tree #914 has visibly suffered at the expense of servicing us humans. After discussing *Balai* as an entire class on Friday, and with English being my last course of the day, I immediately went to the Garden of Contentment after school so I could finish all my assignments due that night (before the chaos of Friday-night ensued). As a result of our class discussion, combined with the fact that I had not visited my tree for multiple days, I approached my tree that afternoon with “fresh eyes.” They helped me to see a new connection between my tree (as well as my experience with it) and our “literary forest,” which was that the life/experience of my tree parallels that of the silk-cotton tree in the story *Balai* written by Rabindranath Tagore. The tree of this story, which Balai holds dear to his heart, is felled at the end of the story. However, as we discussed in class, this only occurs after Balai relocated to Shimla (and then later England). Most likely, Tagore wrote the story in this exact way to instill in us readers that Balai’s very love for the tree itself served as both the figurative and the literal “trunk” for the silk-cotton tree. Once Balai’s uncle realized that Balai’s connection to the tree was severed by him moving away, the uncle made the decision to finally cut down the tree after years of being told “no” for Balai’s sake. Additionally, the mindset

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of Balai's aunt began to change: "And she kept thinking that Balai must have outgrown all those things he had left behind" (Tagore, 653). With Balai gone, the tree having no literal voice, and the tree no longer mattering to the aunt (she only cared for the tree when Balai was around), eventually the appreciation for the silk-cotton tree declined greatly (until it was felled). Balai was the only reason the tree mattered. Similar to Tagore's short story, my tree has declined visibly in its health (documented over the recent years by Baylor students) as people have thought increasingly less about the wellbeing of Tree #914. More specifically, somebody installed an electrical box on my tree which runs under the ground, and my guess is they probably knew the electricity might interfere with the tree's biology/health...but still decided to install it, despite the fact. Even if the former is not true, people since then have become cognizant of this tree's declining health when they record the tree's health annually, but nobody has thought to remove the problem. The only way the tree will ever remove that harm is when a person cares enough to think about the tree (to have somebody who can stand up for it, because the tree matters to that person). Unless people stop by and enjoy the electricity and shade provided by the tree, AND think about the tree which is providing it, the poor tree will remain forgotten about until somebody cares enough (like me or Balai). Not only will it's sacrifice be forgotten, but the tree will remain unappreciated and abused with more electrical lines likely to be added with time and additional limbs are likely to be removed.

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Extra (might be right or wrong) (not apart of submission)

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